SEMA · DJ102 · LESSON 10 · PAIRS · 3 NOV 2026

The Business of DJing

> **Can we make a living from our art, and what systems would make that work last?**

Work through these seven tasks with a partner. You need a notebook, a pen, your mixes and photos, and one phone per pair. The afternoon runs 13:00–17:00 and the evening 18:00–20:30, with a meal break between. Money is in Kenyan shillings (KES).

BEFORE YOU START

Decide who is **Partner A** and who is **Partner B**. You swap roles in every task, so both of you talk and both of you listen.

- **Talker:** explains, answers, does the sums out loud.
- **Asker:** asks the questions in the task, and keeps asking "Where's the proof?" and "What happens if that goes wrong?"

PAIR RULES

1. Use real numbers, not "around something".
2. Write down what's an estimate and what's a confirmed quote.
3. Only share your partner's phone number or photos if they say yes.
4. This lesson is not legal, tax or financial advice. When a clause or a tax question is unclear, write it down to ask a qualified person.

1

45 min

What Do You Promise?

Your offer, your audience, your proof.

On your own (10 min). Write three words you want a booker to think when they see you. Then finish this sentence:

> *"I play _____ for _____ at _____, and you can hear it in _____."*

EXAMPLE

Vague: "I play all genres for everyone." Clear: "I play amapiano and Afro house for 20-something dance crowds at Nairobi rooftop and bar nights, and you can hear it in my 60-minute Sunset Sessions mix."

STRANGER TEST · 15 MIN

Swap phones. Open your partner's Instagram, TikTok, Mixcloud, SoundCloud or wherever they post. You have **2 minutes** and you may not talk. Then write:

- Three words *you* would use for this DJ.
- What music you think they play, and for which crowd.
- One thing that made you trust them, and one thing that made you unsure.

Swap back. Compare their three words with yours.

Promise and proof (15 min). Together, fill this table for each of you. Every promise needs something a booker can see or hear.

I say I am...	Proof I already have	Proof I'm missing
"A sunset DJ"	One sunset mix on Mixcloud	Photos from a real sunset gig; a venue that would vouch for me
"Reliable"	Nothing public	A short quote from a promoter I've played for

Fix it (5 min). Rewrite your sentence so it only promises what you can prove today.

2

65 min

What Is a Gig Worth?

Costing your fee from the ground up.

A fee is not only the hours on stage. It pays for preparation, getting there, your gear wearing out, admin, tax and the night you couldn't take another job. Learn these words first.

Word	What it means
Fixed cost	You pay it whether you play or not: headphones, laptop, music subscriptions, data bundles.
Variable cost	It changes with each gig: transport, prep hours, food, hiring a controller.
Opportunity cost	What you give up to take this gig: another booking, a shift at work, sleep before a big day.
Contingency	Money set aside for what goes wrong: a late-night taxi, a broken cable. Use 10%.

Word	What it means
	Your fees written down, so you don't invent a number on

EXAMPLE: A 3-HOUR BAR SET IN WESTLANDS

Cost	How	KES
Preparation	5 h digging and practising × 500	2,500
Performance	3 h × 500	1,500
Transport	Matatu there, taxi home after midnight	1,800
Gear and music	Share of headphones, USBs, record pool	700
Admin	Calls, invoice, posting the flyer: 1 h × 500	500
Contingency	10% of the above	700
Tax set-aside	Example only: ask what applies to you	800
Minimum fee (below this you lose money)		**8,500**

Minimum covers your costs. **Target** (about 1.5 × minimum) also pays for growth: new photos, a better mix, gear. **Premium** (2 × or more) is for short notice, long travel, big brands, or when they want to record and use your set.

Your turn (40 min). Together, cost all three gigs below for each of you. Write every line, not just the total. Then swap notebooks and check each other's sums.

A. Friday bar set

3 hours at a bar in your town. Their gear. Home after midnight.

B. Wedding in Nakuru

5 hours, bring your own controller and speakers, travel the day before, stay overnight. The couple sends a playlist two days before.

C. Community fundraiser

A friend's event for a local school. No budget. *Do you play for free, at cost, or ask for something else? Write what you'd say.*

SAY YOUR NUMBER · 5 MIN

Each of you says your target fee for gig A out loud, three times, without "um", "like" or "maybe". Your partner says "Again" until it sounds like you mean it.

3

70 min

Fishbowl and Contract Clinic

Bookings, money, paperwork, and what goes wrong.

FISHBOWL · 35 MIN, WHOLE GROUP

Four chairs in the middle, everyone else in a circle around them. Only the four in the middle speak. To join, tap someone's shoulder and take their chair. The facilitator calls a new topic every 4 minutes:

- EPKs, press photos, websites and portfolios
- Where to host mixes (Mixcloud, SoundCloud, YouTube) and what each allows
- Contracts and technical riders
- Payment: flat fee, door split, bar share, deposit, paying after the gig
- Conflict: late payment, cancelled gigs, a set cut short
- Collaborations and B2B sets: who gets paid what
- Self-funded events: what you risk and what you keep
- Licensing: music in public needs a licence from collecting societies (such as MCSK, KAMP and PRISK). Who pays, the venue or you?

Sitting outside? Write one thing you heard that you didn't know, and one question for the panel.

Contract clinic (35 min, in pairs). Read this booking message and the agreement under it. Mark every line with one of three labels.

`✓ Clear` `⚠ Risk` `? Ask a qualified person`

THE BOOKING MESSAGE (WHATSAPP)

"Hey! Loved your mix 🔥 We're launching our rooftop this Saturday, 6pm to late. Great exposure, our page has 40k followers. We pay after the event once we see the numbers. Bring your controller, ours is being fixed. We'll film everything for our socials. Let us know asap!"

THE AGREEMENT THEY SEND LATER

1. DJ will perform from 20:00 to "close".
2. Fee: KES 6,000, paid within 30 days of the event.
3. No deposit.
4. The venue may cancel at any time without payment.
5. The venue owns all photos, video and audio recorded on the night and may use them forever, for any purpose.
6. DJ provides own equipment. The venue is not responsible for damage.
7. DJ must post the event three times on their own accounts.

Then write your version. For each ⚠ line, write the change you'd ask for. For example: *"Set ends at 01:00; extra hours at KES 2,000 each."* or *"50% deposit to confirm; balance paid before I leave the venue."*

Hint. Look for: exact times, the full fee and when it's paid, a deposit, what happens if either side cancels, who owns recordings and for how long, who provides and insures the gear, hospitality (water, food, guest list), and a name and number for the person in charge on the night.

4

75 min

Build Your EPK

Everything a booker needs, in one link.

An **EPK** (electronic press kit) helps a booker say yes quickly. Each of you builds your own; your partner tests it. Keep it light: one PDF under 5 MB or one free link page, so it opens on mobile data.

Part	What to include
Bio	A 60-word version and a 150-word version. Who you are, what you play, where you've played, one proud moment.
Photos	Three: a clear portrait, one playing live, one wide. Landscape and portrait. Credit the photographer, and ask them first.
Mixes	Two links: one that shows your sound, one that fits the gigs you want. Say the length and genre.
Proof	Venues and events played, residencies, radio, a short quote from a promoter.
Rider	Your technical rider from Session 05: the gear you need, plus hospitality.

Part	What to include
Contact	A booking email or a work number, not your personal one. Your social handles.

Build (45 min). Use what's free: a Google Drive folder, a one-page Canva PDF, a link page, or your own site. Write your bios in your notebook first, then type them.

60-SECOND BOOKER TEST · 15 MIN

Send your EPK to your partner. They have 60 seconds, then must answer without looking again:

1. What do you play, and for which crowd?
2. Where have you played?
3. Which mix would they send to a promoter?
4. What gear do you need?
5. How do they book you?

Every question they couldn't answer is something to fix. Then they open every link, on their phone, and tell you which ones broke or were slow.

Fix (15 min). Fix the gaps your partner found. Write down anything you still need: a new photo, a better mix, a quote.

5

75 min

Design Your Own Event

Concept, line-up, budget, poster.

In your pair, you are now promoters. Design one event you could really put on.

1. **Concept (10 min).** Name, sound, crowd, day and time, venue idea, ticket price. Who is it for, and why would they leave the house?
2. **Line-up (15 min).** Book three or four of your classmates. **Booking rule:** you may only book a peer who can show you an EPK, a press photo and a mix. If they can't, tell them exactly what's missing.
3. **Budget (25 min).** Every cost, with each one marked *estimate* or *quote*. Add 10% contingency. Work out how many tickets you must sell to break even.
4. **Safety and access (5 min).** Security, first aid, water, a way home at night, and whether someone in a wheelchair can get in.

5. **Poster and marketing (20 min).** Make the poster on a phone (Canva or similar is fine). Spell every name the way the artist does. Plan three posts: announce, line-up, last call.

EXAMPLE BUDGET

Cost	Estimate or quote	KES
Venue hire	Quote	15,000
Sound hire and engineer	Estimate	20,000
3 DJs × 5,000	Agreed	15,000
Security, 2 people	Estimate	4,000
Poster boosts and printing	Estimate	3,000
Transport and water for the team	Estimate	2,000
Contingency 10%		5,900
Total		**64,900**

Break-even = total ÷ ticket price. At KES 500 a ticket: 64,900 ÷ 500 = 129.8, so you must sell **130 tickets** before you make a shilling.

PITCH IT · 5 MIN
Show your poster to another pair. In one minute: the name, who it's for, the line-up, and how many tickets you need to sell. They ask one hard question.

6

35 min

Negotiation Role-Play

Ask, state your value, offer options, put it in writing.

A plays the **promoter**, B plays the **DJ**. Do two scenarios, then swap. The DJ uses your real target fee from Task 2.

A. "We only have 3,000."

Your target is three times that.

B. "We'll pay after the event."

Last time a promoter said this, you waited two months.

C. "Can you just play the whole night?"

You were booked for two hours. It's now six.

D. "Sorry, we've cancelled."

It's the day before. You turned down another gig for this one.

Four moves for the DJ.

1. **Ask:** "What's the budget for the whole night? What times? Whose gear?"
2. **State your value:** "My fee for a three-hour set is _____, because _____."
3. **Offer an option:** "For that budget I can do one hour, or a B2B with _____."
4. **Put it in writing:** send the message below before you hang up.

> *"Hi _____, confirming: I'll play _____ on _____ from _____ to _____. Fee KES _____, _____% deposit by _____, balance on the night. You provide _____. Please reply to confirm."*

7

25 min

Action Plan

What's missing, and when you'll make it.

On your own (10 min). List every asset you're still missing from Tasks 1, 2 and 4. Give each one a day and a time.

When	What to make
Wednesday	Bio: the 60-word and 150-word versions, with feedback from your partner.
Thursday	Proof: choose two mixes and three photos. Write down who took each photo and that they said yes.
Friday	Money: your rate card, an invoice template and your payment terms.
Weekend	EPK version one. Test every link on a different phone.
Before Jadili	Hand in: EPK, rate card, rider, event budget, event concept and your questions for the panel.

FEEDBACK SWAP · 10 MIN

Partner gives one strength they saw today, what it does for a booker or a crowd, and one exact next step. You repeat it back in your own words before you decide what to use.

SAY IT OUT LOUD · 5 MIN

> *"The asset I'm missing most is _____, and I'll make it on _____ at _____."*